

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707-1740s) - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707-1740s)	
REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC CODES FIRST	
01 MEANING, SCOPE AND GOVERNING THESIS "Disintegration" is accurate for the imperial command structure but	02 EVIDENCE BASE AND SOURCE CRITICISM (METHOD) Convert every major claim into claim - named evidence -
03 IMPERIAL STRUCTURE INHERITED IN 1707 Mansabdars held numerical ranks and owed service; many were paid	04 LATE-AURANGZEB STRAINS: BALANCED ASSESSMENT Conflict with Marathas after Jangam Singh's death and difficulties with
05 SUCCESSION AND COURT CHRONOLOGY, 1707-1713 Technically, Succession and court chronology, 1707-1713 is analysed	06 FARUKHSIYAR, THE SAYYID BROTHERS AND KINGMAKER POLITICS, 1713-1720 The Sayyid ascendancy ended, but long-lasting had permanently
07 MUHAMMAD SHAH, NIZAM-UL-MULK AND THE SHRINKING CENTRE The subsequent "hunger" and stories of pleasure describe court culture	08 NOBILITY, FACTIONS AND THE POLITICS OF PATRONAGE Significance: Political division became military failure because no
09 JAGIRDARI AND MANSABDARI CRISIS: MECHANISM AND DEBATE Mansabdar and jagir were not separate problems; a rank without	10 AGRARIAN AND FISCAL STRESS: PEASANTS, ZAMINDARS AND REVENUE FARMERS Bihar Chauras was heavy demand, border and revenue farming to
11 DECCAN LEGACY AND THE MARATHA CHALLENGE Technically, Deccan legacy and the Maratha challenge is analysed by	12 JAT, SIKH, RAJPUT, BUNDELA AND ZAMINDAR ASSERTIONS Higher capture of strongholds did not erase the social-military
13 HYDERABAD, BENGAL AND AWADH: SUCCESSOR STATES His military and fiscal consolidation built a semi-autonomous state	14 REGIONAL MAP IN TEXT: A MULTI-CENTRED POLITICAL FIELD Awadh connected the middle Ganga plain to Delhi and the northwest;
15 MILITARY ORGANISATION, TECHNOLOGY, COMMAND AND LOGISTICS At Karnal, disputes over who should command and uncoordinated	16 TRADE, ECONOMY AND URBAN CENTRES: CONTRACTION WITH REGIONAL VITALITY Later conflict grew around the use and abuse of power and private
17 COURT AND CULTURE UNDER MUHAMMAD SHAH These works are material evidence for patronage and social worlds;	18 NADIR SHAH'S INVASION, KARNAL AND DELHI, 1738-1739 Karnal was the compressed battlefield expression of the wider crisis
19 WHY CENTRAL AUTHORITY DECLINED: MULTI-CAUSAL INTERACTION MODEL Fiscal stress weakened service; weak service reduced collection; lower	20 CONTINUITIES AFTER POLITICAL CONTRACTION They retained original forms because those forms remained
21 HISTORIOGRAPHY: DARK AGE, CRISIS OR REGIONAL TRANSITION? Delhi suffered catastrophic violence in 1739, and warfare burdened	22 TERMINOLOGY, TIMELINE, MEMORY HOOKS AND ANSWER TOOLKIT Technically, Terminology, timeline, memory hooks and answer toolkit

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which formulation best defines Mughal decline in this package?

Which formulation best defines Mughal decline in this package?

- A. Loss of enforceable central fiscal-military authority amid continuing institutions and legitimacy B. Replacement of Persian administration by Company rule in 1719 C. Immediate disappearance of the dynasty in 1707 D. Uniform collapse of every regional economy

Answer: A.

Explanation: Decline is level-specific: central command contracted while the dynasty, revenue idiom and cultural order persisted.

Trap logic: Do not equate imperial contraction with instant civilisational collapse.

Q2. Which sequence correctly describes the administrative scale from smaller to larger?

Which sequence correctly describes the administrative scale from smaller to larger?

- A. Pargana -> subah -> sarkar B. Pargana -> sarkar -> subah C. Subah -> pargana -> sarkar D. Sarkar -> subah -> pargana

Answer: B.

Explanation: A pargana grouped villages, a sarkar grouped parganas and a subah was the larger province.

Trap logic: UPSC often reverses the middle and upper units.

Q3. Canonical concept check 3

Be-jagiri most precisely referred to:

- A. Permanent hereditary ownership of crown land B. A Maratha levy on Mughal provinces C. Lack or delay of a suitable jagir for a claimant D. Confiscation of all zamindari rights

Answer: C.

Explanation: Be-jagiri identifies assignment scarcity or delay within the mansab-jagir system.

Trap logic: It is not a general word for corruption.

Q4. Which is the strongest qualification to a single-cause 'weak successors' thesis?

Which is the strongest qualification to a single-cause 'weak successors' thesis?

- A. Succession ceased to matter after Bahadur Shah B. Provincial governors possessed no independent revenue base C. Every post-1707 emperor was militarily stronger than Aurangzeb D. Capable nobles existed, but incentives directed their capacity into factional and regional power

Answer: D.

Explanation: Zulfiqar Khan, the Sayyids, Nizam-ul-Mulk and Murshid Quli Khan show that talent survived while institutional alignment failed.

Trap logic: Do not replace a ruler-only thesis with a nobles-only thesis.

Q5. Canonical concept check 5

Bahadur Shah I's Deccan policy is best described as:

- A. Partial conciliation that recognised sardeshmukhi but failed to settle chauth and Maratha succession B. Total military destruction of Maratha power C. Transfer of Hyderabad to the English Company D. Full recognition of Tarabai as sole Maratha ruler

Answer: A.

Explanation: His policy tried accommodation but left Shahu-Tarabai rivalry and fiscal claims unresolved.

Trap logic: Partial concessions are not the same as a durable settlement.

Q6. Canonical concept check 6

Zulfiqar Khan's importance lies primarily in:

- A. Defeating Nadir Shah at Karnal B. Showing both the administrative potential and coalition danger of a powerful wazir C. Founding the state of Bengal D. Abolishing the mansabdari system

Answer: B.

Explanation: He pursued conciliation and fiscal restraint, but emperor and nobles feared an over-mighty minister.

Trap logic: Avoid reducing his career to Jahandar Shah's court anecdotes.

Q7. Canonical concept check 7

The Sayyid Brothers' conflict with Farrukhsiyar centred most directly on:

- A. A doctrinal dispute over Sufi orders alone B. Company annexation of Bengal C. Control of appointments, seal, jagirs, army and provincial resources D. Whether Persian should replace Turkish

Answer: C.

Explanation: The struggle concerned the operational levers of sovereignty.

Trap logic: Religious slogans used later by opponents do not define the original institutional dispute.

Q8. Which statement about the Sayyid Brothers is incorrect?

Which statement about the Sayyid Brothers is incorrect?

- A. They helped place Farrukhsiyar on the throne B. Their deposition of Farrukhsiyar damaged monarchical prestige C. They pursued conciliation with Rajputs, Jats and Marathas D. They formally abolished the Mughal dynasty and founded their own royal house

Answer: D.

Explanation: They remained kingmakers within the Timurid framework and never founded a Sayyid imperial dynasty.

Trap logic: Kingmaker does not mean emperor.

Q9. Canonical concept check 9

The 1718-19 Maratha settlement associated with the Sayyids sought to:

- A. Exchange recognition of Shahu's claims and fiscal rights for service and political support B. Transfer Bengal customs to the Marathas C. Make Nizam-ul-Mulk Peshwa D. End all Maratha collection outside the swarajya

Answer: A.

Explanation: The settlement tried to convert conflict into regulated fiscal-military partnership.

Trap logic: Legal recognition did not guarantee uniform implementation.

Q10. Why was Muhammad Shah's early reign still a possible recovery moment?

Why was Muhammad Shah's early reign still a possible recovery moment?

- A. The jagirdari system had already been abolished B. Chronological stability, continuing prestige and surviving military-administrative resources remained C. Nadir Shah had become a Mughal ally D. All provinces resumed full remittance

Answer: B.

Explanation: The early 1720s retained resources that a coherent centre might have mobilised.

Trap logic: Recovery was possible, not assured.

Q11. Canonical concept check 11

Nizam-ul-Mulk's move to the Deccan in 1724 is best understood as:

- A. A nationalist declaration against all Mughal culture B. A complete rejection of coins and khutba in the emperor's name C. Conversion of imperial office and military networks into practical regional autonomy D. An English-sponsored conquest of Hyderabad

Answer: C.

Explanation: Hyderabad retained imperial forms while command and revenue became regional.

Trap logic: Autonomy is not identical to formal modern independence.

Q12. Which pairing is correctly matched?

Which pairing is correctly matched?

- A. Churaman - foundation of the Nizamat of Arcot B. Nizam-ul-Mulk - foundation of Bengal C. Murshid Quli Khan - foundation of Hyderabad D. Saadat Khan - foundation of autonomous Awadh

Answer: D.

Explanation: Saadat Khan was appointed to Awadh in 1722 and built its semi-autonomous order.

Trap logic: Successor-state founders are a frequent attribution trap.

Q13. Canonical concept check 13

Turani, Irani, Afghan and Hindustani labels should be treated as:

- A. Recruitment and affinity networks within fluid coalitions B. Fixed modern political parties with permanent manifestos C. Revenue units below the pargana D. Religious sects with no connection to office

Answer: A.

Explanation: Origin and kinship mattered, but alliances shifted around office, jagirs and survival.

Trap logic: Do not harden flexible court blocs into permanent ethnic parties.

Q14. Which mechanism most directly links jagir pressure to military weakness?

Which mechanism most directly links jagir pressure to military weakness?

- A. Jagirdars were legally forbidden to employ cavalry B. Inadequate yields and arrears encouraged mansabdars to maintain fewer troops than sanctioned C. Khalisa revenue automatically went to Maratha forts D. All artillery was owned by zamindars

Answer: B.

Explanation: The service bargain failed when paper rank and real fiscal support diverged.

Trap logic: A large mansab did not guarantee a field-ready contingent.

Q15. Canonical concept check 15

The jama-hasil gap refers to the difference between:

- A. Chauth and sardeshmukhi
- B. Imperial coin and provincial coin
- C. Assessed revenue and revenue actually realised
- D. Cavalry rank and infantry rank

Answer: C.

Explanation: Paper assessment could exceed collection because of resistance, devastation or administrative weakness.

Trap logic: Do not confuse assessment with cash available to the army.

Q16. Canonical concept check 16

John F. Richards's qualification to a simple jagir-shortage thesis stresses that:

- A. No jagirdari problem existed anywhere
- B. Only religious policy mattered
- C. Bengal had ceased cultivation by 1700
- D. Allocation choices and the treatment of Deccan khalisa could make the crisis partly policy-produced

Answer: D.

Explanation: Resources, allocation and realisation must be distinguished.

Trap logic: A qualification is not a total rejection of fiscal crisis.

Q17. Ijara created which recurring risk?

Ijara created which recurring risk?

- A. A contractor's incentive to extract above the fixed payment promised to government
- B. A ban on cash revenue
- C. Permanent restoration of village autonomy
- D. Automatic conversion of peasants into mansabdars

Answer: A.

Explanation: Revenue farming inserted cash-rich intermediaries whose profit could intensify pressure.

Trap logic: It could coexist with commercial sophistication and coercion.

Q18. Which statement best captures zamindars in the Mughal order?

Which statement best captures zamindars in the Mughal order?

- A. They were identical to European freehold landlords
- B. They were local right-holders and armed intermediaries whose cooperation or resistance shaped collection
- C. They had no role in peasant mobilisation
- D. They were salaried clerks without local ties

Answer: B.

Explanation: Zamindars linked the state to locality and could convert that position into rebellion or rule.

Trap logic: Avoid both 'mere collector' and 'absolute owner'.

Q19. Canonical concept check 19

The most balanced reading of peasant participation in Jat or Sikh assertion is:

- A. Religion alone explains every participant
- B. Peasants acted without any intermediaries
- C. Agrarian grievance became durable through local leadership, identity, forts and armed organisation
- D. Revenue pressure played no role

Answer: C.

Explanation: Material grievance and political organisation worked together.

Trap logic: Do not erase either agrarian structure or identity.

Q20. Which claim about eighteenth-century agriculture is safest?

Which claim about eighteenth-century agriculture is safest?

A. Only European capital financed agriculture B. Cultivation stopped throughout India after 1707 C. Every region experienced equal prosperity D. Severe extraction and resistance coexisted with expansion and monetisation in some regions

Answer: D.

Explanation: Regional variation is essential to the decline-versus-transition debate.

Trap logic: Do not convert a regional example into an all-India total.

Q21. Canonical concept check 21

Chauth is best described as:

A. A Maratha claim conventionally represented as one-fourth of assessed revenue B. A ten per cent imperial customs duty C. A Mughal tax on non-Muslims D. The salary rank of a mansabdar

Answer: A.

Explanation: Chauth was a fiscal-political claim imposed or negotiated in territories beyond the core swarajya.

Trap logic: It was not simply a village land-revenue rate.

Q22. Canonical concept check 22

Sardeshmukhi is conventionally distinguished from chauth as:

A. A Sikh levy in Punjab B. An additional ten per cent claim linked to superior regional right C. A synonym for imperial khalisa D. A European sea customs pass

Answer: B.

Explanation: The two Maratha claims had distinct conventional bases even when bargained together.

Trap logic: Do not reverse the quarter and ten-per-cent associations.

Q23. Why did the 1718-19 Maratha settlement not end Deccan conflict?

Why did the 1718-19 Maratha settlement not end Deccan conflict?

A. The Deccan had no local forts or sardars B. The settlement contained no fiscal provisions C. Competing Maratha, Mughal and Nizam interests made legal recognition difficult to enforce D. Shahu immediately abolished the Peshwa's office

Answer: C.

Explanation: A sanad could frame rights but not eliminate rival collectors and political centres.

Trap logic: Documentary grant is not uniform implementation.

Q24. Canonical concept check 24

Baji Rao I's wider significance within this topic is:

A. He founded Awadh in 1722 B. He restored Mughal control over Punjab C. He led Nadir Shah's Persian army D. He shifted Maratha strategy toward sustained expansion into Malwa, Gujarat and north Indian politics

Answer: D.

Explanation: Maratha pressure moved from Deccan survival to wider fiscal and political reach.

Trap logic: Reach should not be equated with uniform territorial administration.

Q25. Canonical concept check 25

Churaman is associated with:

- A. Jat power in the Agra-Mathura region B. Persian victory at Karnal C. Sikh mobilisation at Lohgarh D. Hyderabad's foundation

Answer: A.

Explanation: Churaman's networks illustrate fortified zamindari and negotiated resistance.

Trap logic: Do not confuse Jat and Sikh leaders.

Q26. Canonical concept check 26

Banda Bahadur's movement is important because it:

- A. Served as Nadir Shah's frontier army B. Combined Sikh political-religious mobilisation with a major challenge to Mughal authority in Punjab C. Created the twelve misls after 1765 within this period D. Established Bengal's revenue administration

Answer: B.

Explanation: The movement survived the limits of Bahadur Shah's campaigning even though later Sikh phases lay beyond the core period.

Trap logic: Do not begin Sikh political history with Ranjit Singh.

Q27. Which statement about Rajput politics is most accurate?

Which statement about Rajput politics is most accurate?

- A. Their conflicts were purely religious B. Rajputs ceased receiving mansabs after 1707 C. Rajput rulers could seek high Mughal office while bargaining for regional autonomy D. All Rajput houses formed one permanent anti-Mughal coalition

Answer: C.

Explanation: Jai Singh and Ajit Singh demonstrate simultaneous imperial participation and regional assertion.

Trap logic: Avoid binary loyalist/rebel labels.

Q28. Canonical concept check 28

The strongest common feature of Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad was:

- A. Direct creation by Ahmad Shah Durrani B. Formal republican constitutions C. Complete abolition of Persian administration D. Provincial office converted into hereditary autonomy while Mughal legitimacy was retained

Answer: D.

Explanation: All three were successor states, but each rested on a distinct regional base.

Trap logic: Common origin does not make their later institutions identical.

Q29. Canonical concept check 29

Murshid Quli Khan's Bengal order depended significantly on:

- A. Tight revenue collection, major zamindars and merchant-bankers B. Maratha control of the Bengal mint C. Direct annual election by village councils D. Abolition of land revenue

Answer: A.

Explanation: Provincial fiscal capacity rested on collaboration with landed and financial elites.

Trap logic: Efficient collection could still be socially coercive.

Q30. Canonical concept check 30

The Jagat Seth house illustrates:

A. A Sikh misl in Punjab B. The political importance of credit, remittance and mint-linked finance in Bengal C. The disappearance of Indian bankers before Plassey D. A Mughal artillery corps

Answer: B.

Explanation: Bankers were not decorative merchants; they connected revenue, government and political coalition.

Trap logic: Commercial vitality did not guarantee political neutrality.

Q31. Which best describes Saadat Khan's relation to Delhi?

Which best describes Saadat Khan's relation to Delhi?

A. He immediately rejected every Mughal title B. He became Peshwa after Baji Rao C. He built Awadh autonomy while continuing to seek imperial office and confirmation D. He ruled Bengal as Murshid Quli's deputy

Answer: C.

Explanation: Provincial state-building and court ambition remained intertwined.

Trap logic: Do not project later complete separation backward.

Q32. Canonical concept check 32

Hyderabad's continued use of the emperor's name on coins and in khutba indicates:

A. Absence of any regional autonomy B. Direct daily taxation by Delhi C. Conversion of Hyderabad into a European colony D. Layered sovereignty and the continuing value of Mughal legitimacy

Answer: D.

Explanation: Symbolic recognition coexisted with practical independence in war, appointment and revenue.

Trap logic: Symbols are politically real but not proof of direct control.

Q33. Which statement correctly distinguishes the three successor states?

Which statement correctly distinguishes the three successor states?

A. Bengal was strongly commercial-fiscal, Awadh a Ganga-plain military-revenue state, Hyderabad a contested Deccan polity B. They had identical elite coalitions and geography C. All three were founded after Nadir Shah's death D. Only Awadh retained Mughal forms

Answer: A.

Explanation: Common Mughal ancestry produced different regional trajectories.

Trap logic: A matrix answer earns more than a generic list.

Q34. Why is the phrase 'political vacuum' inadequate?

Why is the phrase 'political vacuum' inadequate?

A. No territory changed political hands B. Regional states, zamindars, Marathas and financiers exercised organised power as Delhi weakened C. European companies withdrew from India D. The emperor maintained full coercive control

Answer: B.

Explanation: Power was redistributed, not removed from society.

Trap logic: Rejecting 'vacuum' does not deny violent instability.

Q35. Which was a central military weakness of the later Mughal host?

Which was a central military weakness of the later Mughal host?

- A. Legal prohibition on cavalry B. Dependence solely on European infantry C. Composite contingents and factional commanders lacked reliable unified coordination D. Complete absence of artillery

Answer: C.

Explanation: Karnal shows how divided leadership nullified considerable resources.

Trap logic: Do not use a crude technology-only explanation.

Q36. Canonical concept check 36

A high mansab in 1739 did not necessarily reveal:

- A. The holder's nominal rank B. A recognised service status C. A claim on imperial patronage D. The number of paid, equipped and deployable soldiers actually present

Answer: D.

Explanation: Fiscal shortfalls and inspection weakness separated paper strength from battlefield strength.

Trap logic: Nominal figures should not be treated as headcounts.

Q37. Canonical concept check 37

Nadir Shah's comparative military advantage is best stated as:

- A. Unified command, mobility, disciplined fire and flexible use of artillery B. Naval blockade of Delhi C. Exclusive possession of all gunpowder technology D. Support from a united Mughal nobility

Answer: A.

Explanation: The Mughals had guns; Nadir integrated force and decision more effectively.

Trap logic: Avoid 'modern guns versus medieval swords'.

Q38. Canonical concept check 38

The northwest frontier failed before Karnal mainly because:

- A. Nadir approached through Bengal B. Warnings, diplomacy, reinforcement and command were not converted into a coherent defensive system C. Kabul had never been connected to Mughal strategy D. The Marathas controlled Qandahar

Answer: B.

Explanation: The court received embassies and reports but lacked timely institutional response.

Trap logic: Information alone is not preparedness.

Q39. Canonical concept check 39

Farrukhsiyar's 1717 farman to the English Company primarily concerned:

- A. Transfer of Bengal sovereignty to the Company B. Military conquest of Hyderabad C. Commercial privileges in Bengal, later contested through passes and private trade D. Appointment of a Company governor of Awadh

Answer: C.

Explanation: The farman was a legal-commercial privilege with later political consequences.

Trap logic: Do not convert trade privilege into territorial grant.

Q40. Which economic statement is most defensible?

Which economic statement is most defensible?

A. Bengal trade ended in 1717 B. Delhi had no commerce after 1739 C. Every rupee not sent to Delhi disappeared from circulation D. Decline in imperial remittance could coexist with stronger regional treasuries and markets

Answer: D.

Explanation: Resources were redistributed toward regions, though social costs and war remained.

Trap logic: Centre and region must be analysed separately.

Q41. Canonical concept check 41

Satish Chandra's caution about Nadir Shah's booty is used to show that:

A. Famous totals should not be treated as proof of immediate all-India economic collapse B. The Peacock Throne remained in the Diwan-i-Khas C. The invasion had no fiscal effect D. No treasure was removed from Delhi

Answer: A.

Explanation: Plunder was severe, but the scale and long-term economic interpretation require qualification.

Trap logic: Avoid both exaggeration and minimisation.

Q42. Canonical concept check 42

Muhammad Shah's patronage of music and painting demonstrates:

A. Cultural patronage automatically restored provincial remittance B. Cultural vitality could coexist with political and military contraction C. Court music caused the jagirdari crisis D. Regional courts stopped supporting artists

Answer: B.

Explanation: Culture is an independent evidentiary dimension, not a proxy for governance.

Trap logic: Do not moralise aesthetic life into causation.

Q43. Canonical concept check 43

Dargah Quli Khan's Muraqqa-i Dehli is especially useful for:

A. Exact all-India peasant income statistics B. Official Persian casualty totals at Karnal C. Urban and courtly life in Muhammad Shah's Delhi D. The legal text of the 1717 farman

Answer: C.

Explanation: It supplies an urban social view that complements political chronicles.

Trap logic: Delhi-centred observation cannot represent every region.

Q44. Which was a plausible motive for Nadir Shah's invasion?

Which was a plausible motive for Nadir Shah's invasion?

A. A plan to establish permanent Persian rule over Bengal B. A Sikh request to conquer Delhi C. A verified invitation from Nizam and Saadat Khan D. Resources for a war-making Persian state combined with Mughal frontier weakness

Answer: D.

Explanation: Fiscal-military motive, wealth and opportunity explain more than unsupported invitation stories.

Trap logic: Satish Chandra notes no documentary proof of the invitation claim.

Q45. Canonical concept check 45

The conventional modern date of the Battle of Karnal is:

A. 24 February 1739 B. 24 February 1748 C. 13 March 1757 D. 13 January 1719

Answer: A.

Explanation: Modern reference works conventionally date Karnal to 24 February 1739.

Trap logic: Do not confuse Karnal with the first Durrani invasion in 1748.

Q46. Canonical concept check 46

Karnal is best interpreted as:

A. The origin of every Mughal problem B. An external battlefield test that exposed pre-existing fiscal and command weakness C. A Maratha victory over Nadir Shah D. The formal end of the Mughal dynasty

Answer: B.

Explanation: The invasion accelerated and publicised decline already visible in factions and regions.

Trap logic: Event and structural cause must be separated.

Q47. Which claim about the Delhi massacre is methodologically safest?

Which claim about the Delhi massacre is methodologically safest?

A. The event was invented by Company records B. Every chronicle gives the same number C. The massacre occurred, but a single precise casualty total should not be asserted as settled D. No civilian violence occurred

Answer: C.

Explanation: Catastrophe is certain; totals vary across rhetorical and retrospective sources.

Trap logic: Numerical restraint is evidence discipline, not denial.

Q48. Nadir Shah's settlement with Muhammad Shah did which of the following?

Nadir Shah's settlement with Muhammad Shah did which of the following?

A. Installed the Sayyid Brothers as rulers B. Abolished the Mughal dynasty C. Annexed the whole Gangetic plain to Persia D. Left Muhammad Shah on the throne while transferring wealth and frontier territories west of the Indus

Answer: D.

Explanation: Nadir extracted and withdrew rather than constructing Persian government over north India.

Trap logic: Plunder and annexation west of the Indus are distinct from ruling Delhi.

Q49. Which was not a consequence of 1739?

Which was not a consequence of 1739?

A. Immediate uniform destruction of all Indian trade and urban life B. Greater frontier exposure C. Encouragement to provincial and local assertion D. Severe loss of imperial prestige

Answer: A.

Explanation: Delhi and regional commerce showed resilience even after a severe political-fiscal shock.

Trap logic: Do not infer all-India collapse from capital-city catastrophe.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q50. Canonical concept check 50

The first Durrani invasion in 1748 is used here only to show:

A. The root cause of the 1707 succession war B. A bounded frontier consequence after Nadir's death and the continued possibility of Mughal resistance C. The end of Maratha power in the Deccan D. The creation of Rohilkhand

Answer: B.

Explanation: It lies at the edge of scope and should not displace the 1707-1739 explanation.

Trap logic: Keep later Afghan history bounded.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q51. Which causal ordering is strongest?

Which causal ordering is strongest?

A. Culture declined, therefore jagirs disappeared B. Company trade ended, therefore Bengal became rich C. Fiscal strain weakened service; weak service reduced collection; lower collection intensified faction and autonomy D. Nadir invaded, therefore Aurangzeb fought in the Deccan

Answer: C.

Explanation: The decline operated through a self-reinforcing fiscal-political loop.

Trap logic: Good answers explain mechanisms, not just list factors.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q52. Which statement best captures Mughal continuity?

Which statement best captures Mughal continuity?

A. Every successor state abolished mansabs immediately B. The khutba lost all political meaning C. Persian ceased to be used after 1707 D. Regional powers appropriated imperial titles, documents and revenue practices even as Delhi lost command

Answer: D.

Explanation: Continuity lowered the legitimacy cost of regional state formation.

Trap logic: Institutional survival does not mean unchanged operation.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q53. Canonical concept check 53

Muzaffar Alam and C.A. Bayly are most useful for arguing that:

A. The eighteenth century involved regional reordering, commercial networks and redistributed power B. The Mughal centre remained fully sovereign C. Nadir Shah created Bengal's banking system D. Agrarian pressure never existed

Answer: A.

Explanation: Revisionist work corrects a total-dark-age narrative.

Trap logic: It must be balanced against warfare and unequal social costs.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q54. Canonical concept check 54

Jadunath Sarkar's older interpretation is most often associated with:

- A. The claim that jagirs never existed B. Aurangzeb-centred, personality, moral and political decline C. A denial that emperors mattered D. The portfolio-capital thesis

Answer: B.

Explanation: The older view supplies political narrative but risks moral and communal reduction.

Trap logic: Name the interpretation and then qualify it.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q55. Which is the best historiographical synthesis?

Which is the best historiographical synthesis?

- A. Every region followed the same agrarian trajectory B. No meaningful decline occurred at any level C. Central fiscal-military decline plus uneven regional state formation and continuing economic-cultural vitality D. Only moral decay mattered

Answer: C.

Explanation: A two-level, regionally qualified verdict incorporates the strongest evidence.

Trap logic: Balance does not mean treating every thesis as equally explanatory.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q56. Canonical concept check 56

A coin in Muhammad Shah's name issued within a successor state most directly proves:

- A. Absence of regional taxation B. The emperor's personal presence at the mint C. Daily administrative control by Delhi D. A public claim to Mughal legitimacy

Answer: D.

Explanation: Numismatic titlature reveals acknowledged sovereignty and political language.

Trap logic: Material symbols require an implementation limit.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q57. Why could Mughal legitimacy survive military contraction?

Why could Mughal legitimacy survive military contraction?

- A. It remained a recognised language for title, succession, revenue rights and arbitration B. The emperor controlled every provincial treasury C. European companies prohibited local coins D. Regional rulers had no armies

Answer: A.

Explanation: Existing institutions made imperial sanction useful even to autonomous powers.

Trap logic: Symbolic power can have practical political value.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q58. Which answer line is strongest for Aurangzeb's responsibility?

Which answer line is strongest for Aurangzeb's responsibility?

A. His empire had already ceased to exist before his death B. His Deccan and coalition choices aggravated structural strain, but post-1707 institutions and actors determined the trajectory C. He had no role because he died in 1707 D. He alone caused every event through religious policy

Answer: B.

Explanation: Balanced causation distinguishes inherited strain from later mechanisms.

Trap logic: Avoid both exoneration and total blame.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q59. Which statement about 'dark age' is most defensible?

Which statement about 'dark age' is most defensible?

A. It is fully refuted by one prosperous merchant B. It proves culture disappeared C. It captures real imperial and social disruption but fails as an all-region description D. It is a precise statistical category

Answer: C.

Explanation: The period was neither uniform collapse nor uncomplicated regional prosperity.

Trap logic: Use levels, regions and social groups.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q60. Canonical concept check 60

The most useful final verdict on Nadir Shah is:

A. Founder of a permanent Persian Mughal dynasty B. The sole structural cause C. Economically irrelevant D. Decisive in timing and prestige, secondary to deeper causes of decline

Answer: D.

Explanation: His invasion transformed perception and frontier security but depended on prior weakness.

Trap logic: Accelerant and revealer are not euphemisms for no impact.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q61. Which distinction best captures Mughal decline after 1707?

A. Central enforcement weakened while dynastic legitimacy and administrative vocabulary persisted. B. Trade ceased across India. C. All regional states rejected Mughal forms. D. The dynasty vanished immediately.

Answer: A. Explanation: Central enforcement weakened while dynastic legitimacy and administrative vocabulary persisted.

Q62. What did the Sayyid Brothers' kingmaking primarily demonstrate?

A. A fixed law of primogeniture worked. B. Court coalitions could control accession without becoming emperors themselves. C. Nadir Shah ruled Delhi. D. Jagirs became private estates.

Answer: B. Explanation: Court coalitions could control accession without becoming emperors themselves.

Q63. Why is a high jama not proof of a strong imperial treasury?

A. It abolished local intermediaries. B. It recorded military victories. C. Jama was an assessed claim that could exceed realised hasil. D. It measured coinage only.

Answer: C. Explanation: Jama was an assessed claim that could exceed realised hasil.

Q64. How should Aurangzeb's Deccan wars be used in explanation?

A. As an event after Nadir Shah. B. As proof that provinces had no agency. C. As the sole cause of all later decline. D. As an inherited fiscal-military strain within a wider causal interaction.

Answer: D. Explanation: As an inherited fiscal-military strain within a wider causal interaction.

Q65. Which inference from provincial autonomy is safest?

A. Governors could retain Mughal symbols while controlling practical revenue and patronage. B. Every province became a modern nation-state. C. Coinage proves direct Delhi taxation. D. All governors stopped using imperial titles.

Answer: A. Explanation: Governors could retain Mughal symbols while controlling practical revenue and patronage.

Q66. What does Nadir Shah's victory at Karnal most directly reveal?

A. Mughal legitimacy disappeared that day. B. Fragmented Mughal command was vulnerable to a coordinated invading force. C. The invasion caused every earlier fiscal strain. D. Persia annexed the Gangetic plain.

Answer: B. Explanation: Fragmented Mughal command was vulnerable to a coordinated invading force.

Q67. Which actor belongs to the agrarian-regional feedback rather than only court politics?

A. Only foreign merchants. B. A single chronicler's adjective. C. Zamindars negotiating, resisting or withholding cooperation. D. The Peacock Throne as an object.

Answer: C. Explanation: Zamindars negotiating, resisting or withholding cooperation.

Q68. Which claim should be rejected in a core answer?

A. Jagirdari pressure affected service ties. B. Succession wars weakened arbitration. C. Regional assertion had varied routes. D. Aurangzeb alone explains the post-1707 imperial crisis.

Answer: D. Explanation: Aurangzeb alone explains the post-1707 imperial crisis.

Q69. What is be-jagiri?

A. A shortage of sufficiently productive and usable jagirs for claimants. B. A title for the provincial diwan. C. A category of private freehold. D. A Persian invasion route.

Answer: A. Explanation: A shortage of sufficiently productive and usable jagirs for claimants.

Q70. Why should the core chronology stop in the 1740s?

A. Nadir Shah became Mughal emperor. B. Later Durrani invasions and Panipat are consequences or bridges, not this topic's core causal field. C. Mughal institutions ended in 1740. D. Nothing happened after 1740.

Answer: B. Explanation: Later Durrani invasions and Panipat are consequences or bridges, not this topic's core causal field.

Q71. What is the best use of coin and khutba evidence?

A. It makes farmans unnecessary. B. It proves universal prosperity. C. It can show a claim to Mughal legitimacy but not daily administrative obedience. D. It proves a modern national border.

Answer: C. Explanation: It can show a claim to Mughal legitimacy but not daily administrative obedience.

Q72. Which answer structure is most defensible?

A. List only emperor nicknames. B. Equate all regions with Delhi. C. Treat invasion as the lone origin. D. Weigh succession, faction, fiscal-military strain, regional assertion and Nadir's shock together.

Answer: D. Explanation: Weigh succession, faction, fiscal-military strain, regional assertion and Nadir's shock together.

Q73. Why did short jagir tenure create pressure?

A. It could reward rapid extraction over durable local cooperation. B. It made all zamindars royal officials. C. It abolished mansab service. D. It guaranteed higher hasil.

Answer: A. Explanation: It could reward rapid extraction over durable local cooperation.

Q74. What continuity qualified the image of total collapse?

A. Delhi no longer mattered symbolically. B. Regional rulers continued to use Persianate offices, grants and legitimacy idioms. C. All cultural production stopped. D. No rulers maintained armies.

Answer: B. Explanation: Regional rulers continued to use Persianate offices, grants and legitimacy idioms.

Q75. Which wording is safest about 1739 Delhi?

A. It erased all regional economies. B. It permits a fixed casualty total without sources. C. It was a severe prestige and fiscal shock with contested numerical estimates. D. It established permanent Persian rule.

Answer: C. Explanation: It was a severe prestige and fiscal shock with contested numerical estimates.

Q76. What separates faction from ethnicity in this context?

A. Only one group held office. B. Every noble acted only by birthplace. C. Faction ended in 1720. D. Patronage coalitions shifted and cannot be read as permanent ethnic voting blocs.

Answer: D. Explanation: Patronage coalitions shifted and cannot be read as permanent ethnic voting blocs.

Q77. Which factor is an external shock rather than an original internal mechanism?

A. Nadir Shah's 1739 invasion. B. Provincial retention of resources. C. Jagir-realisation mismatch. D. Succession conflict.

Answer: A. Explanation: Nadir Shah's 1739 invasion.

Q78. What did regional assertion do to imperial capacity?

A. It instantly ended symbolic sovereignty. B. It reduced reliable remittance and made central enforcement more difficult. C. It removed all local diversity. D. It guaranteed Company conquest.

Answer: B. Explanation: It reduced reliable remittance and made central enforcement more difficult.

Q79. Which conclusion reflects institutional continuity?

A. Administrative terms vanished in 1707. B. Decline ended all record-keeping. C. Mughal political grammar outlasted Mughal capacity to command it. D. Autonomy required abandoning titles.

Answer: C. Explanation: Mughal political grammar outlasted Mughal capacity to command it.

Q80. What is the final qualified verdict?

A. The century was uniformly empty of order. B. Only personalities explain history. C. The century was uniformly prosperous. D. The 1707-1740s saw declining central capacity and uneven regional reorganisation, not one monocausal collapse.

Answer: D. Explanation: The 1707-1740s saw declining central capacity and uneven regional reorganisation, not one monocausal collapse.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART II - VERIFIED/ROUTED PYQS WITH SOLUTIONS

PYQ 01 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q48: eighteenth-century successor states

Verified question: With reference to Indian history, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. The Nizamat of Arcot emerged out of Hyderabad State.
 2. The Mysore Kingdom emerged out of Vijayanagara Empire.
 3. Rohilkhand Kingdom was formed out of the territories occupied by Ahmad Shah Durrani.
- A. 1 only
 - B. 1 and 2 only
 - C. 2 and 3 only
 - D. 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: B, 1 and 2 only. Confidence: high. The repository routing verifies the question, but a locally readable UPSC key is unavailable.

Solved explanation

- Statement 1 is correct in the conventional successor-state genealogy: Arcot or the Carnatic operated under the Deccan/Hyderabad subordination before its nawabs acquired practical autonomy.
- Statement 2 is correct: the Wodeyar kingdom of Mysore emerged from the political field of the Vijayanagara order.
- Statement 3 is incorrect: Rohilla power in Rohilkhand grew from Afghan military settlement and weakening Mughal authority before Ahmad Shah Durrani's major Indian interventions; Durrani did not create it from his occupied territories.
- Topic significance: the question tests whether eighteenth-century states are traced to their correct imperial or regional predecessor and whether later Afghan intervention is projected backward.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates each statement independently, supplies the political genealogy and marks the unavailable official key rather than presenting an inference as official.

PYQ 02 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q45: Mughal administrative hierarchy

Verified question: With reference to medieval India, which one of the following is the correct sequence in ascending order in terms of size?

- A. Paragana - Sarkar - Suba
- B. Sarkar - Paragana - Suba
- C. Suba - Sarkar - Paragana
- D. Paragana - Suba - Sarkar

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: A, Paragana - Sarkar - Suba. Confidence: high.

Solved explanation

- A pargana grouped villages and formed the smaller revenue-administrative unit in this sequence.
- A sarkar grouped parganas.
- A subah was the larger province containing sarkars.
- Topic significance: the hierarchy is the territorial skeleton inherited in 1707. Decline occurred when provincial and local officers appropriated power inside this structure, not because the hierarchy instantly disappeared.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact ascending order and links the fact to the mechanism of provincial autonomy rather than treating it as isolated recall.

PYQ 03 - 2022 GS-I Mains Q2: Company armies and Indian rulers

Verified adjacent question: Why did the armies of the British East India Company - mostly comprising Indian soldiers - win consistently against the more numerous and better equipped armies of the then Indian rulers? Give reasons. (10 marks, 150 words)

Routing note: The direct owner is Modern History Topic 05. It is included here only as a verified bounded consequence because the 1707-1740s transition created a competitive multi-state field; it did not itself make Company victory inevitable.

Model answer

The Company's victories arose less from the ethnicity of its soldiers than from the organisation that converted them into a reliable fiscal-military force. Indian rulers inherited capable cavalry, artillery and revenue systems, but their armies were often composite contingents tied to chiefs. The Mughal experience at **Karnal (1739)** shows how divided command could neutralise numerical strength; Maratha confederate chiefs and successor states later faced similar coordination problems, though in different forms.

By contrast, the Company combined regular drill, standardised infantry-artillery coordination and promotion within a single command. Its coastal bases and British naval network sustained supply, while London and Indian merchant credit financed long campaigns. Political intelligence, diplomacy and alliances divided opponents. After **Plassey (1757)** and especially the **Diwani (1765)**, Bengal revenue increasingly funded further war.

Yet victory was contingent: Mysore, Marathas and Sikhs repeatedly imposed serious reverses. The decisive advantage was a cumulative organisation-credit-revenue system, not inherent European bravery or Indian military incapacity.

Why this earns marks: It answers "why" through six mechanisms, uses Karnal only as bounded background, names Plassey and Diwani as later fiscal turning points, and qualifies inevitability with Indian resistance.

PYQ coverage conclusion

The audited repository routes one directly relevant eighteenth-century successor-state Prelims question and one administrative-inheritance question. No direct GS-I Mains question confined to Mughal decline in 1707-1740s appears in the audited 2018-2025 route; the verified 2022 Company-armies question is therefore included only as an explicitly bounded bridge. No History Optional question is invented.

PART IV - ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Mains 10M-1 - Distinguish between decline, decentralisation and regionalisation in the Mughal context after 1707.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 150 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

The terms identify different levels of the same transition. **Decline** refers to the loss of enforceable authority at Delhi: repeated succession struggles, the Sayyids' deposition of Farrukhsiyar in 1719 and divided command at Karnal in 1739 show that the emperor could no longer arbitrate elites or defend the frontier.

Decentralisation describes the movement of revenue and appointment power from the centre to provinces. Murshid Quli Khan in Bengal, Saadat Khan in Awadh and Nizam-ul-Mulk in Hyderabad retained Mughal offices but made collection, military command and succession increasingly regional.

Regionalisation goes further: provincial governors, zamindars, bankers and military groups formed durable political arenas. Bengal's large zamindars and Jagat Seth finance, Maratha chauth networks, and Jat-Sikh mobilisation reveal new coalitions below Delhi.

The processes overlapped but were not identical. Coin, khutba, Persian chancery and imperial confirmation survived, so political force shifted before Mughal legitimacy disappeared. The period was therefore decline at the centre, decentralisation of functions and uneven regionalisation of power.

Why this earns marks: It defines all three terms, supplies three distinct evidence clusters, shows overlap without collapsing categories and ends with a precise two-level verdict.

Mains 10M-2 - Were the Sayyid Brothers merely destroyers of Mughal authority? Examine.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 150 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

The Sayyid Brothers were both products and accelerants of the Mughal crisis, not merely destroyers. Abdullah Khan and Husain Ali raised Farrukhsiyar in 1713 because succession already depended on armed noble coalitions. Their conflict with him concerned the imperial seal, appointments, jagirs and Deccan resources - the substance of sovereignty.

They also attempted repair. Satish Chandra records their abolition of jizya and pilgrim taxes, conciliation of Jai Singh, Ajit Singh and Churaman, and the 1718-19 settlement that exchanged recognition of Shahu's fiscal claims for Maratha support. These were efforts to widen the ruling coalition.

Yet their deposition and killing of Farrukhsiyar in 1719 made Timurid monarchy visibly dependent on kingmakers. Rapid enthronements and patronage promises intensified jagir factionalism; opponents could then rally around dynasty, old nobility and religion. Husain Ali's assassination and Abdullah's defeat in 1720 ended their power, not the underlying crisis.

Thus the Sayyids administered creatively under structural pressure, but their coercive kingmaking deepened the loss of monarchical authority.

Why this earns marks: It directly tests the word 'merely', balances policies against consequences, names offices, rulers and settlements, and distinguishes symptom from agency.

Mains 10M-3 - Explain why the invasion of Nadir Shah was an exposure rather than the origin of Mughal decline.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 150 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Nadir Shah's invasion was possible because the imperial system had already weakened. Before 1739, Farrukhsiyar had been deposed by noble kingmakers; Nizam-ul-Mulk had converted Deccan office into Hyderabad autonomy in 1724; Bengal and Awadh retained revenue; and mansabdars often failed to maintain full contingents because jagir yields and cash were unreliable.

The frontier reproduced this failure. Delhi did not turn Nadir's repeated embassies or the fall of Qandahar and Kabul into timely reinforcement. At **Karnal, 24 February 1739**, Muhammad Shah's leading nobles disputed command. Saadat Khan engaged without an integrated plan, Khan-i-Dauran was mortally wounded, and Nadir's unified mobile force prevailed.

The invasion nevertheless accelerated decline. Delhi suffered massacre and plunder; the emperor ceded territories west of the Indus; prestige collapsed; and regional actors saw that the centre could not protect itself. But Muhammad Shah remained emperor, Delhi recovered commercial life and Mughal legitimacy survived.

Karnal was therefore an X-ray of a prior fiscal-command crisis and a severe new blow, not its original disease.

Why this earns marks: It proves pre-existing weakness with four named units, explains Karnal's mechanism, gives real consequences and avoids minimising the invasion.

Mains 15M-1 - Critically examine the jagirdari-agrarian crisis as an explanation of Mughal decline.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 250 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

The jagirdari-agrarian thesis is powerful because it links elite politics, rural extraction and military weakness, but it must be regionally qualified.

Institutional mechanism: Satish Chandra argues that mansab and salary claims outgrew dependable assignments. *Be-jagiri*, competition for productive jagirs and the diversion of khalisa weakened the centre's cash. The **jama-hasil** gap meant that paper assessment did not equal realised revenue.

Rural transmission: Frequent transfer encouraged short-term extraction. Bipan Chandra notes the spread of **ijara**, under which contractors promised a fixed sum and sought profit from cultivators. Irfan Habib connects high surplus demand to peasant flight, arrears and zamindar-led Jat, Sikh and other resistance.

Military consequence: Nobles with inadequate income did not maintain full contingents. Thus fiscal weakness reduced coercion; weaker coercion further reduced collection. Court parties then recruited followers by promising ranks and jagirs, as in the Farrukhsiyar-Sayyid conflict.

Qualifications: John F. Richards asks whether Deccan revenues and khalisa choices made part of the scarcity policy-produced. Muzaffar Alam and C.A. Bayly point to agrarian growth, monetisation, bankers and regional states, showing that resources were redistributed rather than universally destroyed. Bengal's strong collection under Murshid Quli Khan is counter-evidence to an all-India production collapse, although it could burden smaller zamindars and peasants.

Therefore the crisis is best treated as a variable mechanism: assignment, extraction and service diverged, but the degree and social outcome differed across regions.

Why this earns marks: It defines the mechanism, uses Chandra, Habib, Richards and revisionist counter-evidence, connects fiscal and military outcomes and gives a qualified rather than absolute verdict.

Mains 15M-2 - The Mughal successor states represented continuity in form and autonomy in substance. Discuss with reference to Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 250 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad did not emerge through one clean declaration of independence. They converted Mughal provincial office into hereditary regional authority while preserving the imperial idiom.

Bengal: Murshid Quli Khan, confirmed governor in 1717, tightened survey and collection through powerful zamindars, transferred troublesome jagirdars and relied on merchant-bankers. Remittance and formal allegiance initially continued, but appointments and dynastic succession became provincial. The Jagat Seth house's later role in treasury and mint shows a regional fiscal coalition.

Awadh: Saadat Khan, appointed in 1722, subdued local rajas and expanded provincial command. Yet he still sought imperial office. Safdar Jung's succession after 1739-40 required gifts and confirmation, proving that autonomy and Timurid sanction reinforced each other.

Hyderabad: Nizam-ul-Mulk left the wizarat and defeated Mubariz Khan in 1724. He conducted war, appointment and revenue regionally, while coins, khutba and mansab vocabulary retained Muhammad Shah's sovereignty. Deccan merchants, revenue intermediaries and military elites gave the state its distinct base.

The states also differed: Bengal was a rich agrarian-commercial province, Awadh a middle-Ganga military-revenue arena and Hyderabad a multi-centred Deccan polity constrained by Marathas and local chiefs.

Thus Mughal administrative forms reduced the cost of regional state-building, while control over revenue and force moved decisively away from Delhi.

Why this earns marks: It compares three states through the same analytical headings, supplies named fiscal and legitimacy evidence, states regional differences and answers both continuity and autonomy.

Mains 15M-3 - How far was Aurangzeb responsible for the decline of the Mughal Empire?

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 250 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Aurangzeb was substantially responsible for intensifying the empire's constraints, but he cannot be made the single cause of a decline worked out after 1707.

Real responsibility: The long Deccan commitment absorbed treasury and troops, added difficult territories and failed to extinguish Maratha mobility. Incorporating Deccani and Maratha entrants increased claims on mansabs and jagirs. The emperor's prolonged southern presence weakened supervision of the north and northwest. Conflict over Marwar damaged a Rajput alliance central to Mughal power; jizya and some temple policies narrowed legitimacy in places.

Necessary qualification: Bipan Chandra notes that administration, army and dynastic prestige remained substantial at Aurangzeb's death. Religious measures were reversed: Bahadur Shah and later the Sayyids restored broad accommodation, while Hindu and Muslim nobles repeatedly allied across faith for office and revenue.

Post-1707 mechanisms: Succession wars killed commanders and made noble coalitions decisive. The Sayyids deposed Farrukhsiyar; Nizam-ul-Mulk regionalised Deccan power; jagir and agrarian pressures weakened contingents; Bengal and Awadh retained revenue; and Muhammad Shah's nobles failed to coordinate at Karnal.

Jadunath Sarkar's ruler-centred reading therefore identifies important agency but becomes inadequate when communal or moral blame replaces institutional evidence. Satish Chandra's jagirdari-Deccan synthesis better explains transmission.

Aurangzeb aggravated the inheritance; later fiscal, political and regional choices converted strain into systemic decline.

Why this earns marks: It answers 'how far' with concession, qualification and ranking; uses Deccan, Rajput, jizya, Sayyids, successor states and Karnal; and attributes historiography accurately.

Mains 20M-1 - Why did Mughal central authority decline between 1707 and the 1740s? Present a weighted multi-causal explanation.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 350 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Mughal central authority declined because the fiscal-military contract that joined emperor, nobility, province and countryside ceased to reproduce revenue, service and obedience. Weak rulers and invasion mattered, but they operated through a deeper interactive crisis.

1. Inherited over-extension: Aurangzeb left a formidable empire, yet the long Deccan war had tied down forces, complicated jagir allocation and failed to eliminate Maratha mobility. Rajput and Punjab difficulties and weakened northwest attention added strain. This was a difficult inheritance, not inevitable collapse.

2. Succession and arbitration: With no fixed succession rule, Jajau in 1707 and the contests after Bahadur Shah's death consumed soldiers and made the throne dependent on noble coalitions. Farrukhsiyar's deposition in 1719 showed that kingmakers could control monarchy; rapid enthronements weakened dynastic awe.

3. Jagirdari-fiscal mechanism: Satish Chandra's *be-jagiri* thesis links a growing body of claimants to inadequate or low-yield assignments. Jama exceeded hasil, khalisa was granted away and frequent transfer promoted short-term extraction. Under ijara, contractors pressed cultivators for profit. Nobles in arrears maintained incomplete contingents.

4. Agrarian and regional feedback: Irfan Habib connects extraction to peasant and zamindar resistance. Jats, Sikhs, Bundelas and local chiefs withheld revenue and fortified power. Revisionist evidence adds that agrarian growth, bankers and monetisation could strengthen regions: Murshid Quli Khan's Bengal was fiscally vigorous even as Delhi lost remittance.

5. Provincial and Maratha reordering: Saadat Khan's Awadh and Nizam-ul-Mulk's Hyderabad converted office into autonomy while retaining imperial legitimacy. Maratha chauth and sardeshmukhi moved from contested exaction to imperial bargaining in 1718-19 and wider expansion under Baji Rao.

6. Military-command failure: The army retained artillery and numbers, but paper mansabs, arrears, slow logistics and factional command reduced usable strength. At Karnal in 1739, divided Mughal action faced Nadir's integrated mobility and fire discipline.

7. External shock: Nadir's victory, the Delhi massacre, plunder and loss west of the Indus devastated prestige and frontier security. Yet regional autonomy and fiscal weakness clearly predated him.

The causal order is therefore weighted: fiscal-military and political structures formed the core; rural and regional movements amplified them; military underperformance transmitted them; Nadir determined the dramatic timing and visibility of collapse. Mughal legitimacy and institutions survived, so the outcome was central decline with uneven regional transition, not instant disappearance.

Why this earns marks: It gives a ranked mechanism rather than a list, uses more than eight named evidence units, separates inherited strain from post-1707 transmission, integrates revisionist counter-evidence and ends with a level-specific verdict.

Mains 20M-2 - Was the eighteenth century in India a 'dark age' of decline or an age of regional transformation? Critically discuss with reference to 1707-1740s.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 350 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Neither label is sufficient alone. The period was a darkening of Mughal central fiscal-military capacity and, simultaneously, an uneven transformation of political and economic power toward regions.

Evidence for decline: Succession contests after 1707 destroyed continuity and empowered factions. Farrukhsiyar's deposition by the Sayyids in 1719 eroded monarchical prestige. Jagir competition, jama-hasil gaps and ijara shifted pressure toward cultivators; Jat, Sikh and zamindar resistance disrupted revenue. Provincial remittance weakened, mansabdars under-maintained contingents and Nadir Shah's victory at Karnal in 1739 culminated in massacre, plunder and frontier loss.

Older narratives associated with Jadunath Sarkar read these developments through Aurangzeb, weak successors and moral-political decay. They preserve chronology and agency but risk treating court conduct and religious policy as complete causation.

Evidence for transformation: Bengal under Murshid Quli Khan created a strong revenue order supported by large zamindars and bankers. Saadat Khan's Awadh and Nizam-ul-Mulk's Hyderabad retained Mughal titles, coins, khutba and administration while regionalising force and revenue. Maratha networks converted chauth and sardeshmukhi into a wide political system; Jats and Sikhs built durable local mobilisation.

Muzaffar Alam and C.A. Bayly therefore stress decentralisation, regional politics, credit and "portfolio" resources. Cultural evidence strengthens the case: Dargah Quli Khan's Delhi, Muhammad Shah's music and painting, and the movement of Persianate forms to regional courts contradict total civilisational collapse. Satish Chandra even cautions that the famous economic effect of Nadir's booty is often overstated.

Social and regional qualification: Regional vitality could rest on coercive collection. Murshid Quli's efficient Bengal disadvantaged smaller zamindars; warfare and revenue farming exposed peasants and artisans. Delhi's recovery cannot represent every devastated corridor.

The best synthesis is a two-level history: the imperial centre declined catastrophically, while political authority, commerce and culture were reorganised through regions with unequal benefits and costs. "Transition" is the broader category; "decline" remains indispensable for Delhi's lost capacity.

Why this earns marks: It constructs and tests both sides with political, fiscal, regional, economic and cultural evidence; names historiographical positions; adds social costs; and delivers a non-evasive critical verdict.

Mains 20M-3 - Analyse the relationship between military weakness, regional autonomy and the survival of Mughal legitimacy in the early eighteenth century.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 350 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

The apparent paradox of the early eighteenth century is that Mughal military enforcement contracted while Mughal legitimacy remained the preferred language of new power. The two developments were connected.

Military weakness: The mansab system mobilised composite noble contingents, not one uniformly drilled standing army. Jagir arrears and weak inspection meant that sanctioned rank exceeded deployable troops. Heavy artillery, large camps and capable cavalry remained, but factional commanders disputed precedence and plan. At Karnal in 1739, Saadat Khan's uncoordinated engagement, Khan-i-Dauran's fatal intervention and Nizam-ul-Mulk's constrained role allowed Nadir Shah's unified mobile force to defeat a larger host.

Regional autonomy as response: Where Delhi could not guarantee assignment, protection or arbitration, powerful office-holders internalised resources. Murshid Quli Khan made Bengal's revenue administration provincial; Saadat Khan subdued Awadh's chiefs; Nizam-ul-Mulk transformed the Deccan viceroyalty into Hyderabad after 1724. Marathas extracted chauth and sardeshmukhi, while Jats, Sikhs and zamindars built armed local networks. Military labour and finance followed reliable regional patrons.

Why legitimacy survived: None of these actors operated in an institutional vacuum. The Timurid emperor could still grant mansabs, titles, farmans and sanads that rival claimants recognised. Hyderabad retained coin and khutba in the emperor's name; Safdar Jung sought confirmation in Awadh; Maratha leaders sought imperial documentary

recognition; the English Company relied on Farrukhsiyar's 1717 farman.

Significance: Mughal forms reduced the legitimacy cost of decentralisation. A governor could exercise independent war and taxation while presenting succession as lawful continuity. Control of the emperor therefore remained valuable even after he lost provincial command.

Limit: Symbols were not mere fiction, but neither did they restore cash or battlefield coordination. Their practical effect depended on recognition by nobles, zamindars, merchants and rival states.

Thus military weakness shifted protection and patronage to regions, while the shared Mughal administrative-cultural order enabled that shift to occur without an immediate formal rupture. Force regionalised faster than legitimacy.

Why this earns marks: It answers the relationship rather than three separate themes, uses Karnal, three successor states, Marathas and documentary/numismatic evidence, and distinguishes practical symbolic power from direct control.